in Ramanathapuram.

He told me as if thinking aloud, “Abul! I know you have to go away to grow. Does the seagul not fly across the Sun, alone and without a nest? You must forego your longing for the land of your memories to move into the dwel ing place of your greater desires; our love wil not bind you nor wil our needs hold you.” He quoted Khalil Gibran to my hesitant mother, “Your children are not your children. They are the sons and daughters of Life’s longing for itself. They come through you but not from you. You may give them your love but not your thoughts. For they have their own thoughts.”

He took me and my three brothers to the mosque and recited the prayer Al Fatiha from the Holy Qur’an. As he put me on the train at Rameswaram station he said, “This island may be housing your body but not your soul. Your soul dwel s in the house of tomorrow which none of us at Rameswaram can visit, not even in our dreams. May God bless you, my child!”

Samsuddin and Ahmed Jal aluddin travel ed with me to Ramanathapuram to enrol me in Schwartz High School, and to arrange for my boarding there. Somehow, I did not take to the new setting. The town of Ramanathapuram was